Chapter 5

Search Engine Optimization (SEO) in the AI Era

IN THIS CHAPTER

- **Getting the lowdown on search generative experiences (SGEs)**
- **Recognizing SEO strategies that work with AI**
- **Focusing on user experience**
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Over the last two decades, advancements in internet search algorithms kept the search and browse paradigm at the heart of the internet for billions around the world. Traditional search engines, of which Google is the behemoth, serve up a list of links in response to a user's keyword query. The search engines retrieve results based on their indexing of the content available on the internet and organize the lists of links that they come up with in an order that reflects the content's applicability to the user's inputs.

To take advantage of search engine functionality, companies establish teams to harness the potential of search to acquire customers by writing and optimizing online content that search engines recognize as directly related to user queries. The goal is to have users presented with links (via online search) that match their queries so that they click the links, visit

the company website, and make product purchases. You want to design content pages that rank high in the order of search results against commonly entered search terms. And when a company succeeds in reaching this goal, it can attract large audiences to its products or services.

Creating online content that the search engines can easily read and that Google (for example) ranks highly costs less than running paid advertising online. The practice of crafting website content to make it search-engine friendly is called *search engine optimization* (SEO), which is a critical part of the digital marketing playbook. However, the traditional approach to SEO may be changing with the increased use of artificial intelligence (AI) to create and optimize the content, on the one hand, and the shift toward AI services such as ChatGPT and Perplexity on the other. These AI services bypass the search engines to give users answers to their queries directly in their results windows. In fact, according to Gartner (a management consulting company), online traffic going to websites directly from search engine results will drop 25 percent by 2026 and will be replaced by the use of tools such as ChatGPT, Claude, and Perplexity.

In this chapter, I begin by discussing why and how users are changing the way that they use search engines, what that change means for marketing, and how businesses can adapt their strategies for this change. Although I cover these topics, I also tell you how you can use AI to augment your current SEO efforts — because the move away from search engine dominance isn't an overnight shift, but rather a gradual evolution.

Describing Search Generative Experiences (SGEs)

You can witness the profound impact of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) on internet search through the shift toward more conversational (also known as *natural language*) user interfaces. Users can now engage with search engines in a more natural and human-like manner, asking complex questions or expressing their queries in full sentences, rather than relying on specific keywords.

In turn, AI search engines can synthesize information from multiple sources to provide a comprehensive answer to the question in everyday

English, instead of simply listing websites that contain the relevant keywords. This capability to understand and process natural language queries in real time is beginning to transform search engines from impersonal website directories into knowledgeable assistants. Commonly referred to as *search generative experiences* (SGEs), this shift has profound implications not only for how people use the internet but also for how they create content for it.

When you look toward the future, you can see that the advancements in search algorithms powered by generative AI promise to make the vast expanse of the internet more accessible and understandable for everyone.

Enhanced interpretation of queries

The advent of GenAI has enabled search algorithms to understand and interpret the intent behind queries with unprecedented depth. This evolution from simple keyword spotting to understanding the context and semantics of user inquiries marks a significant leap forward. As SGE technologies continue to evolve, you can anticipate a shift from information retrieval to knowledge generation, in which search engines synthesize information and provide specific recommendations tailored to users' needs by using the rest of the internet as raw material for their responses.



REMEMBER GenAI models, such as Claude (`https://claude.ai/`) and OpenAI's GPT-4 (`http://openai.com/gpt-4`), are trained on vast amounts of data. The scope of the training enables the models to generate responses that provide direct answers, summaries, or even newly written content based on the user's query. Not to be outdone, both Google and Bing also include SGE results at the top of their search engine results pages as of late 2023.

Personalized search results

The use of SGE opens up many possibilities for personalized search experiences. By analyzing the user's past interactions, preferences, and even the context of their current search, AI can tailor the search results more

effectively to meet individual needs. This personalization extends beyond filtering and ranking results based on presumed relevance; it involves generating content or answers uniquely suited to the user's query and context. For example, a search for cooking recipes can take into account the user's dietary restrictions, preferred cuisines, and even the ingredients that they have on hand, offering a level of customization that was previously unavailable.

The transition to custom-crafted search results represents a fundamental change in how people can access and interact with online information, potentially transforming the web into a more dynamic, intelligent, and personalized space.

PERPLEXITY PROVIDES A PEAK INTO THE FUTURE

Perplexity AI (`www.perplexity.ai`) provides a good example of an AI–driven search engine that demonstrates how natural language interfaces are changing the search and browse paradigm of the internet. The search functionality that Perplexity AI offers directly answers users' questions by pulling together information from what it has already gathered by crawling the web. Perplexity AI uses this information to give clear and relevant answers to the questions (rather than just a list of links). This situation makes searching for information faster and easier, turning what used to be a long process into a quick and straightforward task.

Thanks to its advanced understanding of language, Perplexity AI can understand the context of what you're asking, not just the specific words that you use, so it can provide answers that are much more relevant to what you're actually looking for, simplifying the process that you have to follow to find complex information, removing the need to sift through unrelated links. As a result, there's much less ambiguity in your search experience when you use Perplexity AI.

Additionally, Perplexity AI offers a search experience without ads (at least, as of the time I write this book), which means its results aren't influenced by advertisers. This lack of advertiser influence can lead to more unbiased and focused search outcomes. With recent investments and positive feedback from users, AI-driven search engines such as Perplexity AI

are beginning to challenge traditional search engines, pushing them toward adopting new standards for delivering search results.

These AI-driven solutions, such as Perplexity AI, are search generative experiences (SGEs) to the core because they literally generate answers to your questions using the internet as the raw ingredients for that generation exercise. You can get the most benefit from them if you have a specific query in mind and are looking for one answer, rather than browsing for different alternatives. Although I can't say how solutions such as Perplexity AI will change the way people search the internet in the future or how the solutions will crawl the web and influence search engine optimization (SEO), but you should pay attention to these new innovations as they enter the mainstream.

Strategies for SEO Success in the AI Era

For many search engine optimization (SEO) experts, the integration of AI with the domain of SEO means a necessary return to the fundamentals of what makes successful content that human beings care about and search algorithms reward. Returning to fundamentals requires that you focus on the following strategies and tactics that the team at SEO.ai (`https://seo.ai`), a company that offers a highly ranked AI SEO writing tool) have emphasized:

- **Audience focus:** Research your audience and cater specifically to their interests and needs. Tailor content to match their search queries and personas, evidenced by their queries and online habits. This focus can leverage AI's capability to analyze big data for enhanced audience relevance and engagement.
- **Originality:** Prioritize the creation of unique, research-based content that human beings will care about. Stand out with original studies, surveys, and case studies that offer new data. The goal is to ensure that AI-generated content complements your content and that your content retains as much value for both users and search engines. This concept may not feel new, but it matters more with the rise of AI-generated content because it is now increasingly challenging to differentiate between human-created and AI-created material.
- **Structured data:** Implement *structured data* (data that has a standardized format that both software and humans can easily access) so that search engines can easily understand and index your content. This tactic improves your content's visibility to search engines and adapts content for evolving search tech-

nologies (such as voice search) to enhance user experience. It's only a matter of time until marketers learn how large language models (LLMs, such as ChatGPT) read websites. When they do, they'll need to adjust their content to be more accessible to those LLMs. What's clear is that companies that have more structured data will win the battle for recognition from search technologies.

- **Human touch:** Emphasize the human element behind your content. Showcasing real people, emotions, and personal experiences builds trust and connection with your audience, which is an offering that's beyond AI's reach. The human-oriented content — whether it's SEO or any customer-facing content — can continue to successfully carry your message in the future.
- **Real-time updates:** Focus on freshness and the integration of real-time data to ensure that your content remains relevant and up to date. This approach keeps your content ahead of synthetic data (AI-generated material), which may lack the latest information.



REMEMBER As the use of GenAI in marketing increases, the future will bring a lot of AI-created content to compete with your own, so keep your messaging up to date so that it stands out and remains relevant.

- **Domain authority:** Strengthen *domain authority* (a website's quality ranking in Google search) and secure *high-quality backlinks* (other websites linking back to yours). As content saturation increases, these factors become critical for attracting search engines and AI tools that prioritize and trust your content over others. Both practices emphasize the importance of online relationships and external validation. ***Note:*** In 2023, *The New York Times* brought a lawsuit against OpenAI for crawling its content without permission to train its models because the media publisher knows that its online content is valuable.
- **Openness and transparency:** This strategy should feel obvious to any marketer, but it bears stating. To win over your audience in the AI era, having engaging content isn't enough. You need to build trust with your consumers by clearly stating your policies on what data you use in your marketing and how you use it. Don't make the mistakes that CNET did (see the sidebar "A CNET Saga: When AI Slips In," in this chapter).

A CNET SAGA: WHEN AI SLIPS IN

CNET (`www.cnet.com`), a well-respected technology news website, faced public scrutiny in the spring of 2023 upon revealing that it had been using AI to write numerous articles, notably for its daily mortgage and refinance rate section on its website. Despite being attributed to Justin Jaffe, CNET Money's managing editor, these stories didn't appear on Jaffe's pri-

mary author page; instead, they were on a separate page exclusively for mortgage rate stories, raising questions about transparency and authorship.

The controversy intensified when it was reported that CNET had quietly published more than 70 articles under the byline “CNET Money Staff” since November 2022, with only a hidden editorial note indicating the use of AI. This lack of clarity extended within CNET, where even staff members were unsure of how the publisher used AI or the workflow surrounding that use, further complicating the issue. This SEO-friendly content ranked high on Google search results and was monetized through affiliate links. This approach, lucrative for CNET, involved creating content on high-intent queries, such as credit card applications, to earn affiliate fees if a user clicked on the links in the article and went to the credit company’s website. However, because AI produced these articles without any appropriate disclosures or internal checks, it raised serious concerns about the quality of the content.

The ethical concerns were manifold, primarily centered around CNET's initial failure to disclose the use of AI in creating content. This lack of transparency raised significant questions about credibility and the ethical responsibility of media outlets to inform readers about the origins of the content that they consume. Moreover, subsequent investigations revealed instances of factual inaccuracies within the CNET AI-generated articles, highlighting the risks and limitations of relying on AI for content creation. These findings led to a broader conversation on the reliability and ethical use of AI in journalism, emphasizing the need for stringent quality control measures and the development of robust guidelines to govern AI’s application in content creation.

The incident catalyzed a shift toward greater transparency, with CNET and other outlets beginning to label AI-generated content clearly. This case study not only illustrates the potential pitfalls of integrating AI into business without adequate disclosures and quality assurance mechanisms, but it also highlights the evolving dialogue about how best to utilize AI in a manner that supports and enhances reader trust.

Enhancing the User Experience with AI

Optimizing your website or mobile web interface for AI–driven search engines requires a focus on enhancing *user experience* (UX) through strategic design and content approaches. By implementing the tips outlined in this section, you can significantly enhance the user experience of your website or mobile web interface. The enhancements, in turn, make these experiences more favorable in the eyes of AI-driven search engines. The goal is to improve your search engine optimization (SEO) rankings and also drive customer engagement, retention, and sales conversions.

Here are five detailed tips for achieving this goal:

- **Prioritize mobile-first design.** AI search engines recognize the shift toward mobile browsing and heavily favor websites optimized for mobile devices. Creating a responsive design includes
  - Adjusting content and layout based on the user's screen size
  - Using large, touch-friendly buttons and readable fonts
  - Ensuring quick content load times by optimizing images and leveraging modern coding practices

  For example, you can use mobile content frameworks such as AMP (Accelerated Mobile Pages) for presenting news articles. This framework is designed to improve loading speed on mobile devices.
- **Enhance site structure for easy navigation.** A well-organized site structure not only improves usability but also helps AI search engines understand and index your content more effectively. Using *schema markup* to outline the structured data implementation (a strategy presented in the preceding section) on your site can help AI understand the context and content of your pages, improving the chances that your site gets featured in *rich snippets* (the blurbs that the search engines publish at the top of search results pages).
  Create a logical hierarchy in your website's architecture, including a clear menu structure and *breadcrumb navigation* (a structure that facilitates navigation by clearly showing users where they are and where they can go next within the website).

  

  TIP Make each page of your website or mobile interface accessible within a few clicks (no more than four if you can help it) from the home page.
- **Optimize for voice search.** With the rise of AI assistants such as Siri and Google Assistant, optimizing content for voice search is crucial. Incorporate nat-

ural language processing (NLP) by including *long-tail keywords* (a phrase made from three to five words) and questions that people are likely to ask as a search prompt in conversational language. Focus on localized SEO by ensuring that your business is listed on Google My Business and other directories because many voice searches are location-based. For instance, include common voice query phrases such as *near me* or *how to* in your content.

- **Improve content relevance and quality.** AI search engines prioritize content that's relevant and offers substantial value to the user. Follow these simple steps to enhance user experience and keep visitors on your website or mobile interface longer:
  - Use AI tools to analyze top-performing content in your market niche and identify key topics and questions that your audience is interested in.
  - Create comprehensive, well-researched content that addresses these topics and questions.
  - Make use of headings, subheadings, and bullet points for better readability.
  - Add engaging multimedia content, such as videos and infographics.
- **Leverage AI for personalized user experiences.** Personalization is key to enhancing UX and improving SEO rankings with AI search engines. Use AI to analyze user behavior and preferences to deliver personalized content recommendations, product suggestions, and targeted promotions. Implement chatbots to provide instant assistance and guide users through your website.
  As an example, Netflix uses AI algorithms to recommend movies and TV shows based on individuals' viewing habits. This strategy significantly enhances the user experience and encourages longer session durations.

Maximizing Your SEO Efforts

You can incorporate AI tools and techniques into several aspects of your company's SEO practices. A holistic approach to this piece of your marketing presence — powered by AI — propels SEO from mere optimization to a strategic, insight-driven endeavor. Specifically, you can leverage AI for

- **Keyword and metadata research:** Helps you create content that not only reaches, but also engages, the target audience effectively. When AI helps with your research, SEO strategies can become more aligned with the constantly changing user trends and competitive SEO dynamics, where different companies fight to rank higher in the search results pages. (I go into more detail about this form of research in the following section.)
- **Content development and optimization:** Streamline the creation process and ensure that content aligns with user intent and preferences. Using AI's help, you

can improve your content's SEO quality, user engagement, and sales conversion rates (see the section "Automating content optimization," later in this chapter).

- **The link-building process:** For both your websites and mobile interfaces, adding AI tools to the mix for building links not only makes identifying and securing high-quality backlinks more efficient (as discussed in the section "Building SEO links," later in this chapter) but also ensures that efforts align closely with overall SEO strategy and goals.
- **Predictive SEO:** Enables marketers to be proactive rather than reactive in their SEO strategies. This approach — engaging predictive AI tools — not only enhances the effectiveness of content and SEO efforts, but also ensures that businesses remain agile and responsive to ever-changing user needs and search engine evolutions. Check out the section "Harnessing predictive SEO," later in this chapter, for all the details.

Streamlining keyword and metadata research

The heart of SEO today involves writing content that includes the appropriate *keywords* and *metadata,* which are signals used by the search engines to determine the rankings of the websites in response to a query. Arguably, those same elements are foundational to creating search generative experiences (SGEs), too. (See the section "Describing Search Generative Experiences [SGEs]," earlier in this chapter.) Therefore, you absolutely have to nail the keywords and metadata that you use as a foundation for creating content. Fortunately, AI can help with creating your SGE-ready content.

Integrating AI into keyword and metadata research strengthens SEO practices by making them more dynamic, precise, and user-focused. Here are specific ways that AI can help SEO professionals and marketers, along with insights into implementing these strategies and examples of useful tools:

- **Predictive analysis for trending keywords:** AI algorithms can analyze search data and social media trends to identify emerging keywords before those keywords become popular with users. This early keyword optimization gives marketers a competitive edge.
  Tools such as Google Trends (`http://trends.google.com`) and Semrush's Keyword Magic Tool (`www.semrush.com/features/keyword-magic-tool`) leverage predictive analytics to spot trends. For instance, an AI tool may flag the phrase *sustainable home goods* as an emerging trend. A distinction such as this

enables brands to pivot their content focus accordingly and write strong SEO content that responds to that phrase, even before the trend peaks.

- **Semantic search optimization:** AI's capability to understand the context and intent behind search terms and queries means that SEO isn't just about the keywords anymore. The goal is to create content that genuinely aligns with the context that users are searching for.
  Tools such as Clearscope (`www.clearscope.io`) or MarketMuse (`www.marketmuse.com`) analyze top-performing content to recommend semantically related keywords. This approach ensures that content for a search for *best running shoes* encompasses terms such as *lightweight running sneakers* and *durable running footwear*, closely matching user intent.
- **Personalization of content strategy:** By analyzing user behavior, AI helps tailor keywords and metadata to specific audience segments. Resulting SEO strategies effectively resonate with various audiences and their preferences.
  Marketing platforms such as HubSpot (`www.hubspot.com`) or Salesforce Marketing Cloud (`www.salesforce.com/eu/marketing/`) help you create segmented content strategies. For example, AI analysis may reveal a preference for eco-friendly travel options among millennials; that information provides a guide for focusing a travel agency's SEO content on this area.
- **Automation of keyword and metadata tagging:** Automating the process of tagging content with relevant keywords and metadata saves time and ensures consistency across content. AI-powered SEO tools such as Yoast SEO (`http://yoast.com`) suggest optimal keywords and metadata based on content analysis. When analyzing a blog post about vegan recipes, for instance, an AI tool can automatically suggest adding *plant-based cooking* and *easy vegan meals* as metadata tags.

Automating content optimization

Using AI for automating content development and optimization allows you to fine-tune content to the intended audience and enables precision, personalization, and efficiency in ways previously unattainable by the more traditional writing and publishing content manually.

The following strategies demonstrate how leveraging AI can transform content strategy and delivery:

- **Personalize content.** AI can dissect and understand user data and, thus, tailor content dynamically, enhancing user engagement significantly. A notable example is Spotify's use of AI to curate personalized playlists, an offering that has been instrumental in boosting user engagement and subscription rates. Tools

such as Salesforce's Einstein (`www.salesforce.com/products/einstein`) can help you customize content across various channels based on user interactions and preferences.

- **Enhance SEO.** AI tools, such as Moz (`http://moz.com`) and MarketMuse (`www.marketmuse.com`), can optimize content for search engines, identify gaps in content, and suggest actionable improvements. Users leveraging these insights have reported significant improvements in SERP (search engine results page) rankings and *organic reach* (visibility of content among its desired audience without any paid advertising investments to support it).
- **Streamline content creation.** Automated content generation tools such as OpenAI's GPT-4 (`http://openai.com/gpt-4`), Writer (`https://Writer.-com`), and Jasper (`www.jasper.ai`) can produce draft articles, social media posts, and even e-mail campaigns. This automation can lead to a more efficient content-production process, and marketers have reported significant time savings and increased output without compromising quality.
- **Predict content success.** Platforms such as Optimizely (`www.optimizely.-com`), Contently (`https://contently.com`), and others use AI to evaluate content against a myriad of performance indicators, predicting success and suggesting optimizations. Such predictive capabilities enable marketers to allocate resources more effectively, prioritizing content with the highest potential for engagement and impact.
- **Optimize for voice search.** As voice search becomes increasingly prevalent, AI tools can help optimize content, focusing on conversational keywords and queries. Integrating voice search optimization into content strategies can capture a growing segment of voice-first users (users who prefer to use voice to search over typing in search terms), enhancing visibility across digital assistants and smart devices.
- **Improve engagement by using AI chatbots.** Integrating AI-powered chatbots on digital platforms can offer instant support and personalized content recommendations. This functionality not only boosts engagement, but also gathers insights into user preferences, which may inform future content strategies.

Building SEO links

AI technologies have transformed *link building* (meaning the process of acquiring hyperlinks from other websites to your own to improve search engine ranking), a cornerstone of SEO strategy. You can use AI tools to identify link-building opportunities, automate outreach, and evaluate the quality of potential link sources. The following list gives you some specific opportunities that you can use to leverage AI for link building:

- **Identify link opportunities.** AI tools can scour the internet to identify high-quality, relevant sites that you can establish as potential *backlinks* (links that you can provide on your own page that go to supportive content). By analyzing content relevance, domain authority, and web traffic, AI can help pinpoint the most beneficial link-building opportunities.
  Tools such as Ahrefs (`https://ahrefs.com`) and Majestic (`https://majestic.com/`) provide comprehensive databases and AI-driven insights to streamline this process. For instance, you may use Ahrefs to discover authoritative blogs in the niche of *sustainable living* and identify those blogs that have high user engagement but low external links as prime targets for outreach.
- **Automate outreach for link building.** AI-powered customer relationship management (CRM) and e-mail marketing tools, such as BuzzStream (`www.buzzstream.com`) or Mailshake (`https://mailshake.com`), allow you to automate personalized outreach campaigns to potential link partners. These platforms can segment audiences, personalize messages based on the recipient's interests or recent content, and schedule follow-ups. These actions increase the efficiency and success rate of link-building efforts.
  For example, the ECOgardener company (specializing in eco-friendly gardening tools and supplies) started an automated campaign targeting webmasters of gardening blogs, resulting in a 20 percent positive response rate and several high-quality backlinks.
- **Evaluate link quality.** Beyond identifying opportunities, AI can assess the quality and potential impact of backlinks. By examining factors such as site relevance, link context, and the historical performance of similar links, AI tools can predict the value of a prospective link.
  Semrush's Backlink Audit tool (`www.semrush.com/backlink_audit`), for example, uses AI to evaluate the *toxicity* of existing backlinks (whether those links are indeed trusted, factual, and useful) and suggest new, high-quality linking opportunities. A digital marketing agency may use this feature to strengthen a client's backlink profile, removing or disavowing low-quality links and focusing on acquiring valuable ones.
- **Analyze competitors' links.** AI algorithms can analyze competitors' backlink profiles, offering insights into their link-building strategies and revealing untapped linking opportunities. Tools such as Link Explorer by Moz (`https://moz.com/link-explorer`) analyze thousands of links in seconds, providing detailed reports on where competitors are getting their links and how those links contribute to their SEO performance. By studying these patterns, an SEO strategist can uncover overlooked niches or platforms, such as industry forums or collaboration opportunities with influencers in related fields.
- **Predict link performance.** Some AI tools offer predictive analytics that can forecast the potential SEO impact of a new backlink before you acquire that backlink. SEO managers can then prioritize their link-building efforts based on

predicted outcomes, focusing resources on the most impactful links. This technology has the potential to significantly optimize the return on investment (ROI) of link-building campaigns by focusing on links that offer the greatest boost to search rankings.

Harnessing predictive SEO

Harnessing *predictive SEO* (the practice of forecasting future search trends and optimizing content proactively) by using AI tools allows you to anticipate changes, adapt strategies in real time, and stay ahead of trends. Predictive SEO uses data analytics, machine learning (ML), and other AI technologies to forecast future trends in user behavior, search demand, and content effectiveness.

Here are specific strategies to effectively implement predictive SEO:

- **Forecast search trends.** Utilize AI tools to analyze search data and predict future trends, which can give your business a competitive advantage by enabling you to create or update content that meets emerging demands. As I mention in the section "Streamlining keyword and metadata research," earlier in this chapter, Google's AI-powered tool, Google Trends, offers insights into search trend trajectories, helping marketers identify and capitalize on rising queries. For instance, a digital marketing team may use Google Trends to spot an uptick in interest for *home workout equipment* early in each year and develop targeted content before the peak search period.
- **Optimize content strategy with predictive analysis.** AI platforms such as MarketMuse (`www.marketmuse.com`) and BrightEdge (`www.brightedge.com`) use predictive analytics to suggest content topics and optimization strategies that are likely to perform well. These tools analyze historical data and current market trends to recommend content creation and optimization actions. A content manager can leverage MarketMuse to predict the performance of different content themes on their blog, focusing efforts on those predicted to generate the most engagement and traffic.
- **Improve user experience with predictive user behavior analysis.** AI can analyze user interaction data to predict future behaviors and preferences, enabling websites to tailor experiences to meet anticipated needs. Tools such as Crazy Egg (`www.crazyegg.com`) provide *heatmapping* (a color-coded representation of data) and visitor insights, predicting areas of a website that will likely attract a lot of attention and suggesting layout or content adjustments accordingly. An e-commerce site may use these insights to redesign product pages, placing high-demand items in areas predicted to draw more visitor focus.

- **Anticipate the impact of algorithm changes on SEO.** AI-driven SEO tools such as Moz Pro (`https://moz.com/products/pro`) offer the capability to simulate and predict the impact of search engine algorithm updates on a website's ranking. By analyzing past updates and current website performance, these tools can forecast potential changes in rankings and suggest preemptive optimizations. You may use this feature to tweak your website's content and technical SEO elements in anticipation of a confirmed Google algorithm update, minimizing negative impacts on your site's search visibility.
- **Implement predictive link-building strategies.** You can also employ AI to forecast the value and potential success of link-building efforts. By using tools such as Semrush (`www.semrush.com`) — which assesses the quality of potential backlink sources and predicts the impact of these links on SEO — you can prioritize your outreach efforts more effectively. For example, you can identify and focus on acquiring backlinks from domains that have rising authority in niche markets, as predicted by Semrush's analytics.

Knowing the AI Tools to Use with SEO

Each tool listed in Table 5-1 comes with unique capabilities and artificial intelligence (AI)–driven insights. These tools can help you make informed decisions, streamline workflows, and significantly improve the effectiveness of your SEO strategies.

TABLE 5-1 AI Tools That Help with SEO

Tool	*Website*	*Uses*
Ahrefs	`https://ahrefs.com`	Predicts keyword trends and analyzes the search landscape
BrightEdge	`www.brightedge.com`	Provides content performance metrics, recommendations

Tool	*Website*	*Uses*
		for optimization, and insights into competitive strategies
BuzzSumo	`https://buzzsumo.com`	Analyzes content across the web for insights into what content performs best for any topic or competitor and identifies key influencers
Clearscope	`www.clearscope.io`	Provides keyword and content recommendations for better search engine rankings

Tool	*Website*	*Uses*
Google Trends	`http://trends.google.com`	Analyzes the popularity of top search queries in Google Search across various regions and languages
MarketMuse	`www.marketmuse.com`	Offers content planning, creation, and optimization assistance, identifying content gaps and opportunities for improving topical authority
Moz Pro	`https://moz.com/products/pro`	Offers site audits, keyword research, and backlink analysis, as well as predicting the potential impact of SEO strategies on

Tool	*Website*	*Uses*
		your site's performance
Semrush	`www.semrush.com`	Provides keyword research, SEO audits, competitor analysis, and insights to improve SEO, pay-per-click (PPC), and content marketing strategies
SpyFu	`www.spyfu.com`	Analyzes your competitors' search marketing strategies, offering insights into competitors' keywords, ad variations, and SEO tactics
Surfer SEO	`https://surferseo.com`	Analyzes and compares your content against top-performing

Tool	*Website*	*Uses*
		pages in search engine results and offers guidelines to improve content relevance and SEO performance